

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a local newspaper:

Women still paid badly, survey finds

Women are on average still paid HK\$15 less per hour than men, according to the latest figures released by the government.

The statistics, which were compiled and released by the Hong Kong Census and Statistics Department, showed that the hourly salary of women in Hong Kong in 2017 was HK\$60.50, compared to HK\$75.90 for men. The problem is even worse in terms of monthly income. Young women in the 15-19 age bracket earned HK\$3,100, while young men in the same age range earned HK\$5,300.

Surprisingly, the pay difference is true of men and women of all ages and levels of education. For example, men who had received post-secondary education were paid HK\$118.30 per hour, while women with the same level of education only received HK\$97.80. One reason often cited by apologists of this phenomenon is that it is understandable that women are paid less because they are more likely to leave the work force to take care of family members some time in the future.

Some students expressed disappointment at the news of the gender pay gap. Tiffany Wong, 16, was concerned about traditional views regarding men and women affecting wages. "I think the belief that women are more suited to staying at home, taking care of the children and doing housework while men are better suited to a competitive office environment and working long hours, is still very real. Therefore, employers still tend to consider men for higher paid jobs than their female counterparts. They see it as a safer investment."

Your careers advisor is discussing discrimination in the workplace. Your group has been asked to discuss the gender pay gap. You may want to talk about:

- whether there are differences in job performance between men and women
- why women are generally paid less than men
- how the gender pay gap could be reduced
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. What job would be suitable for you?
2. Are some jobs more suitable for women than men?
3. What jobs are seen as traditionally male or female jobs?
4. In what other ways are women treated unfairly?
5. Should it be illegal for men and women to be paid differently?
6. Will the gender pay gap continue in the future?
7. Apart from gender, why do some people get paid more than others?
8. Is Hong Kong becoming a fairer society?